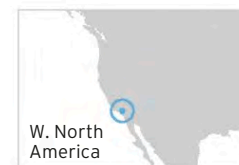


# Walt Disney Concert Hall

*A gleaming temple to the performing arts in Los Angeles, named after one of the movie industry's most famous sons*



The long and successful association between film producer Walt Disney (1901–1966) and Hollywood and the city of Los Angeles was furthered in 1967 when his widow, Lillian, donated an initial \$50 million to build a new concert hall. Her gift would serve not only to enrich the lives of people living in the city but also to stand as a memorial to her husband's close links to the arts.

The new hall, at 111 South Grand Avenue in downtown Los Angeles, was the work of Canadian-born architect Frank Gehry (1929–), whose radical design predated his titanium-clad Guggenheim Museum in Bilbao, Spain (see pp.200–201)—the building that made him famous. The hall's design was completed in 1991, but construction only began in earnest in 1999, due to a lack of funds, and was finished in 2003. The concert hall officially opened with a gala concert on October 24 of the same year.

## Sailing walls

Gehry designed the auditorium to provide audiences with an intimate experience, wrapping them around the orchestra, and paid special attention to its acoustics, lining the walls and ceilings with Douglas fir and the floors with oak to enhance the sound. This functional interior is wrapped in a dramatic sculptural exterior inspired by the architect's love of sailing.

Gehry used a computer program more commonly put to work in the aerospace industry to design the stainless-steel sails that wrap around the building. Some of the concave panels had to be dulled by lightly sanding their surfaces to prevent glare—their reflected light overheating nearby condominiums and increasing the risk of traffic accidents—but once this problem was overcome, the hall took its place as one of Los Angeles's finest buildings.

A note **echoes** in the hall for **2 seconds after** it has been played

